A SUFI SHRINE, A RAJPUT PRINCESS, AND A NOTORIOUS MURDER

On a cold January night in 1562, Akbar and a small group of courtiers were out hunting in the lands around Agra which bristled with deer, birds, cheetahs, tigers, and leopards. Near Mandhakur, a village halfway between Ajmer and Sikri, they came upon a group of singers, probably qawwals, singing the praises of the Sufi saint Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti,* whose dargah was in neighbouring Ajmer. The dargah of the thirteenth-century Sunni mystic was an important pilgrimage site in the sixteenth century, attracting both commoners and kings. Muhammad bin Tughlaq had paid his respects here and because the only Brahma temple was in nearby Pushkar, Muinuddin Chishti's dargah 'became a place where Hindus placed their head and sent nazr every year', according to Shaikh Jamali Kamboh. So Akbar would have heard of the miraculous power of the Ajmer shrine and he decided that he would go there that very night. His courtiers tried to dissuade him as it was a long and dangerous journey but Akbar refused to listen. He sent word that Maham Anaga was to bring the harem via Mewat to join him at Ajmer and the small party left immediately. At the village of Kilaoli, Akbar was informed that a certain Raja Bharmal, the very same raja who had stood steadfastly in front of Akbar's rampaging elephant, now wished to greet him. 'The Raja stands out for his great intellect and courage,' Akbar was told, 'and he had constantly striven in allegiance to this exalted dynasty…' Raja Bharmal and all the important members of his clan were presented to Akbar at the town of Sanganer.

In the sixteenth century, the Rajput kingdoms in western India remained fairly isolated since the defeat of Prithviraj Chauhan by Muhammad Ghori in 1192. Indeed the entire region, a collection of small, intermittently warring principalities, was relatively culturally homogeneous with neighbouring Sind and Gujarat. Oral tradition tells us that major Rajput clans like the Kachhwahas, Rathores, and Sisodiyas originally came from outside Rajasthan and took over lands held by ruling tribes like the Bhils and the Meenas. The need for expansion and consolidation kept the clans constantly battling each other, and so to provide a cohesive military